

Ouija boards

Spirit writing, or *Fuji*, was first practiced in China 1,500 years ago: it involved a suspended stick, apparently guided by spirits, that wrote Chinese characters in ash. Today spirit writing is known chiefly through Ouija boards, patented in the US. Spiritualism (see pp.224–227) became hugely popular after the American Civil War, when many of the bereaved had a desire to contact lost loved ones. In response to this, in 1891 the Kennard Novelty Company launched the Ouija board. It comprised a ring of letters and numbers, and a planchette (pointer) that participants touched; this allowed spirits, it was claimed, to guide the planchette and spell out words.

While some believed spirits of the dead genuinely spoke through the Ouija board, others were more skeptical but saw the practice as harmless fun. Either way, Ouija boards became popular family entertainment. Then in 1973, attitudes abruptly changed in response to the horror film *The Exorcist*, in which a Ouija board enables a demon to “possess” the soul of a young girl. Suddenly, Ouija boards were seen as a terrifying tool of the Devil.

Scientists had another view—since 1852 they had been able to explain the phenomenon of spirit writing. For them, the “supernatural” act of a pointer moving was not the work of spirits but of the ideomotor effect: the living participants subconsciously making tiny muscular movements.

“Ouija, the Wonderful Talking Board [answers questions] about the past, present, and future with marvelous accuracy.”

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